

**DEVI WALK**
Mamata Banerjee leads the march celebrating the grant of UNESCO's ICH tag to Kolkata's Durga Puja festivities

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

recognition was seized upon and used as a show of cultural pride, a sunny diversion as it were. The photo-optics was important to drown the din around corruption charges, even though for a couple of hours. "A Mamata show has a lot of colour and visual impact. A smile, a handshake and eye contact are enough for a seasoned politician like her to feel the political pulse. She was trying to gauge if her mingling with people created the same magic as before," observes social scientist Prasanta Ray. Behind this is Mamata's innate belief that as the nerve centre of the TMC, she alone was the deliverer of people's wishes, irrespective of the bad apples in the party. To show that she doesn't condone corruption, Mamata, too, directed panchayats to crack down on irregularities like 'cut money' and extortion—a common accusation in the past. Her slogan rang out: *panchayat, chor dhoro, jail bhoro*. The message—her own administration will catch the thief and there's no need to look elsewhere to fix the problem. The BJP, too, is targeting Durga Puja for a public outreach, with Union home minister Amit Shah likely to inaugurate a puja.

Mamata's main dole this festive season is a Rs 60,000 grant (10,000 more than last year) to each of the 43,000 puja committees in the state. With other concessions to them, like the waiving of 60 per cent of electricity charges and tax exemption on advertisements, the cost to the exchequer will be over Rs 400 crore. She has also increased the puja break in the administrative calendar by two more days, helping state government employees have a break of 11 days. "With the UNESCO march and puja festivities, the Partha Chatterjee episode will gather dust for a month. Public memory...cannot dwell on a particular thing for long," says political analyst Sovonlal Dutta Gupta.

Besides, Mamata's basket of goodies, especially for women, continues to overflow. The Jaago project involves a financial assistance of Rs 5,000 a year for each of the 1 million registered self help groups, benefitting 10 million women. The Lakshmir Bhandar scheme, whereby a monthly allowance of Rs 1,000 is guaranteed for Scheduled Caste/Scheduled Tribe women and Rs 500 for others, will now be widened to cover 17 million women, an increase of 2 million. It costs the Bengal exchequer Rs 17,000 crore annually.

This apart, Mamata has come up with a new idea of empowering women of backward areas in western and northern Bengal that have a potential of tourism. She has promised a financial assistance of Rs 1 lakh to each family who converts their homes, with government help, into a one-room home stay. The scheme, when initiated, will help many families in the hills of north Bengal and the forests of the west. All this, along with the continuing Kanyashree, Sabujsathi and Rupasree schemes, have kept rural families firmly by Mamata's side. She needs them more now, in her hour of need. ■